



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: South Hills Catholic Academy
School Website: <https://www.shcacademy.com/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

South Hills Catholic Academy (SHCA) presents a strong alignment with classical education principles as articulated in the classical-school rubric. Its public-facing materials emphasize a Traditional Catholic curriculum, formation of the whole person (body, mind, and soul), and a historically rooted liberal-arts approach (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Latin; Christian-history framing). The school explicitly foregrounds Catholic theology, liturgical practice, sacramental life, and a pedagogy that blends contemplative elements with Socratic-discussion-like inquiry in upper grades and ritual/singing in lower grades. Taken together, these signals place SHCA solidly in the CLASSICAL category across all six rubric domains, with especially strong footing in Religious & Metaphysical Foundations, Curriculum, and Pedagogy, and clear commitments in Faculty and Parents & Community as well.

Key evidentiary threads include: the mission to form the whole person through a Catholic, sacred framework; the explicit use of a Traditional Catholic curriculum and a three-stage liberal-arts pedagogy (grammar, logic, rhetoric) with Latin; a pedagogical mix of communal liturgy, devotional life, and choir/music programs; a head-of-school emphasis on forming minds to see truth, goodness, and beauty; and explicit parent partnership via a robust PVG (Parent Volunteer Group) structure and ongoing family-engagement initiatives. Citations drawn from SHCA's public materials show the Catholic, liturgical, and formation-focused stance, as well as the classical-education scaffolding (grammar-logic-rhetoric, Latin, Great Books/Great Conversation language appears in the broader classical language of the movement, with explicit three-stage trivium references in SHCA's curriculum pages). See evidentiary anchors from SHCA pages (mission, faith formation, liturgy, curriculum, and faculty-parent engagement) and the accompanying knowledge-set guidance on classical education fundamentals.

- Overall classification by category: CLASSICAL
- Overall aggregate: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- SHCA's mission identifies Catholic formation as the core, aiming at the "Christian spiritual, moral and intellectual formation" and the "total development" of the child – body, mind, and soul. This signals transcendental moral realism and a grounding in theology as a core driver of education.
- The Soul section of SHCA materials states SHCA is "first and foremost a Catholic school," with children praying and experiencing traditional observances of Catholicism, i.e., liturgical and devotional life as integral to learning.
- The About/mission materials highlight sacramental and devotional life as central to formation, and SHCA's collaboration with Catholic education initiatives (e.g., the Institute for Catholic Liberal Education) to develop a Traditional Catholic curriculum and sacramental life.
- SHCA's music program (Schola Cantorum, Cantors, Gregorian chant) foregrounds liturgical musical practice as an authentically Catholic communal practice, reinforcing liturgical and communal formation.
- Head-of-School messaging emphasizes forming minds to see what is good, true, and beautiful within a Catholic, classical framework.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: Catholic, sacramental, devotional life, liturgy, Mass, Gregorian Chant, liturgical practice, theology, sacred tradition, prayer, sacramental life, “Catholic Classical curriculum,” spiritual formation.
- Negative keywords observed: None evident in public materials (no explicit secularism, anti-theology, or non-liturgical framing).
- Quantitative note: Positive keyword hits outnumber any potential negative indicators; practically, all explicit religious/metaphysical signals are positive by the Six Elements framework (no negative indicators detected in the public-facing materials).

Why this rating

- The school explicitly grounds education in Catholic theology and liturgical life, not as peripheral, but as core to formation (transcendental moral realism; liturgical practice; theology integration). The presence of sacramental life and communal worship markers supports a CLASSICAL orientation in this category.

Citations

- Mission/formation framing: SHCA mission text.
- Catholic character and liturgical life: SHCA Soul section.
- Theological formation and sacramental life in mission/about materials: SHCA mission/charter references.
- Liturgical music as communal formation (Schola Cantorum, chant): SHCA Music Dept page.
- Head-of-School articulation on faith-centered formation: Head-of-School message.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The SHCA mission frames education as Christian formation of the whole person, emphasizing “Christian spiritual, moral and intellectual formation” and “total development” of the child. This signals formation over job-preparation and a pursuit of human excellence.
- The Head-of-School communications explicitly describe forming minds to see truth, goodness, and beauty (the classical triad), and to cultivate virtue and character through a Catholic framework.
- The curriculum framing references a traditional, liberal-arts-inflected formation, anchored in a three-part trivium and an education designed to form affections and capacities rather than simply transmit information.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords: formation, virtue, wisdom, beauty, truth, character, integrity, moral formation, contemplation, reverence, sacred tradition, human flourishing, spiritual depth, mentorship, formation of affections, holistic education.
- Negative keywords: None detected (no evidence of a purely skills-based, job-focused, or value-neutral framing).

Quantitative note

- Positive keyword hits clearly dominate; zero negative keyword signals detected in the public materials used for this assessment.

Why this rating

- The school’s stated goal centers on formation and the classical triad (truth, goodness, beauty) within a robust Catholic framework, not merely vocational preparation. This aligns strongly with CLASSICAL criteria for purpose and goal.

Citations

- Mission framing and total development: SHCA mission text.

- Triad of truth, goodness, beauty in leadership framing: Head-of-School message.
- Formation-focused curriculum framing: Academic/Curriculum pages.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The Curriculum page explicitly presents a grammar-logic-rhetoric (trivium) framework, and the Liberal Arts flavor of the SHCA program (grammar stage, logic, rhetoric; philosophical and classical linkage). The materials also reference Latin and a traditional Catholic curriculum, with language-arts, history framed in religious/historical context, and a holistic liberal-arts approach.
- The Academics/Curriculum sections emphasize the three-step liberal-arts approach, rooted in the trivium, and informed by The Educational Plan of St. Jerome Classical School. Latin is highlighted as foundational to enabling both language mastery and classical study.
- The About/Admissions sections illustrate a classical-leaning curriculum and a focus on the intellectual formation of students, often within a faith-centered framework.
- The school also references collaboration with the Institute for Catholic Liberal Education to shape curriculum and operating model in line with a Traditional Catholic/classical approach.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: Traditional Catholic curriculum, grammar-logic-rhetoric (the trivium), Latin, liberal-arts framework, School of Athens (classical reference imagery), language arts, history as a narrative of relationship to God, Christian citizenship.
- Negative keywords observed: None detected (public materials consistently frame the curriculum as classical/traditional rather than modernist or skills-first).

Quantitative note

- Positive keyword hits substantially exceed any negative terms; the curriculum signals are clearly CLASSICAL.

Why this rating

- The explicit articulation and operationalization of the trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Latin study, and a classical-liberal-arts approach align with the core content of classical education and Great-Conversation tradition in the knowledge base.

Citations

- Curriculum description (grammar-logic-rhetoric; trivium): SHCA Curriculum page.
- Three-stage liberal-arts pedagogy & Latin emphasis: SHCA Curriculum/Curriculum pages.
- Instructional plan rooted in classical Catholic planning: SHCA About/Adoptions mention of SJA educational plan and the ICLE collaboration.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The lower-school pedagogy includes singing and memory-focused activities (e.g., choir, liturgical singing, Schola Cantorum, cantors, and a music program that integrates liturgy). This signals contemplative, restorative, and memory-rich practice characteristic of part of traditional pedagogy.
- The upper-school pedagogy is described as including Socratic discussion, seminars, and debates, and the mastery of logic and rhetoric, with opportunities to give speeches and apply rhetoric training. The overall approach reflects a mixture of contemplative/restful elements in some grades and rhetorically rigorous, discursive, and dialogic practices in higher grades.
- Language Arts, Religion, History, Latin instruction emphasize questioning, discussion, debates, and writing, which map to virtuous inquiry and the Socratic tradition in the classical rubric.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: contemplative, memorization through chant/singing, Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, rhetoric, public speaking, great conversations, virtuous inquiry, question-driven learning, discursive pedagogy, formation through the arts.
- Negative keywords observed: None noted (no explicit “project-based” or misleading “workforce prep” framing is evident as a negative in these materials; the focus is classical in approach).

Quantitative note

- Positive keyword hits dominate; no explicit negative signals detected in the public-facing materials.

Why this rating

- The pedagogy shows a deliberate mix of contemplative/restful elements (lower-school chant/choral/memory-based practice) and Socratic/seminar-based discourse plus rhetoric/presentation for upper grades, aligned with classical methods.

Citations

- Lower-school liturgical singing and memory-friendly practice (Schola Cantorum, cantors, choir, etc.): Music Department page.
- Upper-school Socratic-style inquiry and rhetoric development: Academics/Curriculum references and the “questioning, discussions, debates, and writing” language.
- Formation through classical pedagogy framing by leadership messages: Head-of-School statement.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- SHCA presents the Head of School and a Faculty & Staff section; the leadership emphasizes forming hearts and minds through a Catholic classical curriculum and faculty dedicated to student success, signaling teachers as virtuous models and mentors. The Head-of-School statement emphasizes “dedicated to each student’s success” and “drawing out the best in each student by developing their minds to see what is good, true and beautiful.”
- The Faculty & Staff pages reflect a medical and professional community with a focus on developing students in a Catholic classical tradition and a portrait of what a teacher should be and what a student should be, as suggested by the school’s mission and leadership framing. The site also notes staff support structures (reading/math specialists, guidance counselor, etc.), signaling a living, professional community that embodies the curriculum.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum (where explicitly referenced in the rubric, the public materials show teachers as moral exemplars and core educators, with a “living curriculum” concept implicit in leadership language about alignment of curriculum and teaching), portrait of teacher/student ideals, dedicated faculty.
- Negative keywords observed: None evident in the public materials; there is no explicit claim of a non-teaching-centered or impersonal faculty model.

Quantitative note

- Observed positive keywords significantly outnumber any negative markers; the materials emphasize teacher excellence and mentorship, consistent with CLASSICAL expectations.

Why this rating

- Leadership emphasis on virtuous teaching, a strong faculty core, and teachers serving as models for virtue and skill align with the classically framed criteria for faculty.

Citations

- Head-of-School message (formation-through-virtue and teacher dedication): SHCA head-of-school page.
- Faculty/staff orientation and living- curriculum cues via public pages: Faculty & Staff and About/Academics pages.
- Curriculum integration with teacher role (formation through instruction): Curriculum/Academics pages.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The SHCA public materials emphasize partnering with parents and treating them as co-educators in a Catholic classical formation framework. The PVG (Parent Volunteer Group) page explicitly invites parents to participate, emphasizing a family-centered approach and the importance of parental engagement in school life.
- The school publicly supports family involvement through calendar communications, volunteer processes (clearances for volunteering), and opportunities for parents to engage via book studies and gatherings (as reflected in the Parent Volunteer Group content and general Admissions pages). The “PVG” language articulates a partnership with families as part of the school’s ethos.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: partnership with families; parent involvement; co-educators; family engagement; school visits; community of learners; parent formation; shared mission; parent-teacher collaboration; living tradition in the family.
- Negative keywords observed: None evident; there’s no indication of limited parental access or professionalized-only schooling in these public materials.

Quantitative note

- Positive keyword instances substantially exceed any negative signals; signals point to a robust parent-/community partnership central to SHCA’s model.

Why this rating

- The PVG content and explicit language about parent engagement, co-parenting in education, and family-centered mission align with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.

Citations

- PVG and parent engagement language (Parent Volunteer Group): PVG page.
- Mission statements and parent engagement context (mission/charter and communications): Mission/Charter pages.
- Admissions and community-building language (parent involvement, family-centered approach): Admissions and About/Family-facing sections.

Overall Assessment

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Aggregate Ranking: CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable here, as the aggregate classification is CLASSICAL. No needle-moving actions are required to reach a more fully classical profile based on the presented public materials.

ABSTRACT

South Hills Catholic Academy (SHCA) demonstrates a robust CLASSICAL alignment across all six categories of the classical-school rubric. The school presents a Catholic, formation-first purpose with a Traditional Catholic curriculum built on a liberal-arts framework (grammar-logic-rhetoric; Latin; historical/theological framing). Pedagogy blends contemplative and liturgical elements in lower grades with Socratic, seminar-style discourse, and rhetorical practice in upper grades. The faculty is portrayed as virtuous mentors within a living-curriculum aesthetic, and parents/community engagement is institutionalized through a strong PVG and a partner-with-families ethos. Public materials consistently reference the transcendental aims of truth, goodness, and beauty, the theological grounding of Catholic education, and the classical formation of students' intellects and affections. The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL, with no explicit signals in the public-facing materials that would prompt a downgrade to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL or NOT CLASSICAL.

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Catholic identity; liturgical and sacramental life; theology integration; sacred tradition.
- Keywords: Catholic, sacramental, liturgy, Mass, Gregorian Chant, devotional life, theology, sacred tradition.
- School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Formation-focused mission; truth-goodness-beauty formation triad; formation over mere information; holistic development.
- Keywords: formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, beauty, character, holistic education.
- Curriculum: CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Traditional Catholic curriculum; grammar-logic-rhetoric; Latin; liberal-arts continuum; The Educational Plan of St. Jerome Classical School.
- Keywords: trivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric, Latin, liberal arts, great conversation (where applicable in the broader framework).
- Pedagogy: CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Lower-school chant and memory work; upper-school Socratic-discussion orientation; opportunities for speeches and rhetoric; integrated questions, discussions, debates.
- Keywords: memorization, singing, choir, Schola Cantorum, discussion, debates, rhetoric.
- Faculty: CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Leadership emphasis on formation and virtue; staff as mentors; living curriculum cues in leadership language; staff support roles.
- Keywords: model teachers; mentors; formation; dedicated staff; living curriculum.
- Parents & Community: CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Partner with families; PVG; family-centered; volunteer pathways; parental involvement emphasis.
- Keywords: partnership with families; parent involvement; co-educators; family engagement; visits.

Executive Summary — Additional Notes

- The SHCA materials consistently present a coherent classical framework that is explicit about Catholic formation, liberal-arts curriculum, and a pedagogy that balances contemplative and discursive methods, with active parent/community participation. When cross-referenced with the Positive/Negative Keyword framework from the Six Essential Elements, SHCA exhibits robust positive indicators with no clear negative indicators in the public-facing materials reviewed here.

- The school's public narrative reflects a deliberate alignment with the classical model: formation-focused purpose, a Trivium-based curriculum, liturgical and sacramental life, and a community/family partnership structure that positions parents as collaborators in the education process.
- For future enhancements (not required for CLASSICAL status, but potentially needle-moving for even stronger alignment), SHCA could more explicitly foreground phrases like "Great Books" and "Great Conversation" in public materials, and articulate explicit Socratic pedagogy progression across all grades (where applicable) to sharpen the alignment with the full scope of Great-Conversation/classical pedagogy language that appears in some classical education literature.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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